General Rules

Players and Characters

Players will explore an imaginary world, called the *Setting*, which is populated by various *Creatures*. Creatures fall into two categories:

- **Characters** controlled by the *players*.
- **Non-Player Characters** (**NPCs**) and **Monsters** controlled by the ***Game Master (GM)***.

The players use their characters to interact with the setting, which is controlled by the GM. The GM's role is to adjudicate conflicts and apply rules consistently to ensure narrative stakes and immersion are preserved in the setting.

The Pillars of Play

Monomyth is played as a back and forth conversation between the players and the GM. The GM presents the setting and conflict for the players, the players decide how they want their characters to act, and the GM determines the fallout of their decisions. The iterating of this process builds out a continuous, collective narrative.

This style of play typically falls into three categories:

- **Exploration** - Players investigate new places to find secrets and gain insight.
- **Social Encounters** - Players converse and spend time with NPCs to develop relationships and learn information.
- **Conflict** - Players alternate turns with the GM as they struggle against an opponent, such as through combat, an escape or chase, or a similar conflict.

Resolving Actions

Simple or safe actions should generally be treated as being automatically successful, and the GM should simply narrate what happens as a result. For instance, it isn't necessary to test a player who simply wants to walk up a flight of stairs. However, in the case that

the players want to perform a risky action, where the chance and consequences of failure are not negligible, then the player must perform a **Check**. If a player wants to *leap* up a flight of stairs — to avoid a trap, for instance — the GM should require them to make a check to see if they are successful.

To perform a Check, the player who is acting must roll dice, while the GM sets a target number. If the player meets or beats the GM's target number, they succeed. Otherwise, they fail. In the case that two characters are contesting each other's actions, both characters (be they player characters or GM controlled NPCs) roll, and the higher total result wins.

The Passage of Time

Days within the setting are typically split into 3 segments; *Morning*, *Evening*, and *Night*. Each segment of a day is spent to accomplish a task. It is recommended that the party spend at least one of these segments resting. If the party begins a new day without having rested at any point during the day prior, they gain a level of exhaustion.

Examples of tasks that would occupy a segment of a day include things like delving a nearby ruin, searching for leads and information pertaining to the party's current query, or, working on a project. Players should agree on what to do during a segment of a day, explain to the GM their intent and goals, and then the GM and players progress through a scene (or many scenes) to attempt to advance the party's goals.

Time in the game does not necessarily pass one-to-one with real life. Time in the Setting can be abstracted to pass quickly, condensing hours and sometimes days into a few minutes of playing time. This frequently happens during exploration and occasionally during social encounters, if appropriate.

More often, social encounters pass as though they are real life, and sometimes even slower as players deliberate what to do or say.

Conflict almost always passes at a rate that is much slower than real life. Battling an opponent or escaping a hazardous situation usually consists of a few quick, decisive actions that are often over before even a minute has passed. In Monomyth, conflict is resolved in turns to ensure fairness between players, and this often takes longer than just a few minutes.

Using Dice

Dice are used in Monomyth to simulate the random chance that often passes unnoticed in our daily lives, as well as to heighten tension in the game when the characters are in trouble or endeavoring against uncertain odds.

Monomyth uses; four (d4), six (d6), eight (d8), ten (d10), twelve (d12), and twenty (d20) sided dice. The GM should be clear about what dice they want you to roll, or it will be explicitly mentioned in the rules. ***Checks*** always make use of the d20.

Advantage & Disadvantage

Regardless of the purpose and situation, the GM may grant you advantage or disadvantage on a roll.

- ***Advantage:*** Roll twice and use the higher result.
- ***Disadvantage:*** Roll twice and use the lower result.

Critical Success & Failure

This only applies to ***Checks***. When rolling a d20 on a Check, and you roll a 20, this counts as a critical success – not only do you succeed in your action, but you are so successful that it leads to additional boons. Alternatively, if you roll a 1, then you critically fail, leading to heightened consequences.

Movement & Distance

Abstract Distance

Monomyth uses four ***Distance Bands*** to measure the relative position of characters, creatures, and objects within the Setting: ***Close***, ***Nearby***, ***Far***, and ***Distant***.

This supports a *"Theater of the Mind"* style of play, where maps, charts, and miniatures are not being used. GMs are encouraged to incorporate the names of these distance bands when describing scenes so players can create a mental image of the relative locations of points of interest.

Moving During Conflict

During Conflict, characters can move *along* the chain of distances. This means, on your turn, your character may move towards something that is *Nearby*, making it *Close*, or away from something *Far*, making it *Distant*. Typically, ***to interact with an object, one must be Close to it***.

Melee attacks and touch-based spells must be made at a distance of *Close*, while ranged attacks and spells can be performed at all distances (within reason).

Distance Outside of Conflict

Distance Bands may represent different actual distances depending on the context. For example, while traveling, a *Close* location may describe a place that is reachable within a few minutes or hours of travel, while some place *Near* requires a full day of travel. These distances constitute miles, quite different from how they are used in situations of Conflict, but the spirit of four Distance Bands remains the same.

Character Basics

Abilities

All characters have 6 abilities, which constitute their general competencies.

- ***Strength** (**Str.**)* is your physical power.
- ***Agility** (**Agi.**)* is your balance and physical control.
- ***Endurance** (**End.**)* is your physical fortitude.
- ***Charisma** (**Cha.**)* is your social appeal and presence.
- ***Wisdom** (**Wis.**)* is your knowledge and education.
- ***Willpower** (**Wil.**)* is your magical skill and mental endurance.

Scores

For each ability, your character has a score, which typically ranges between 1 and 20. Roll 3d6 to determine each ability score in the order presented above. Then, you may switch any two scores as you wish.

Modifiers

You can calculate your ability modifiers by taking your Ability Scores, subtracting ten and dividing by 2, rounding down. This yields modifiers that typically range from -5 to +5. These modifiers are added to checks when appropriate. For example, you could add your *Agility* modifier to a Check to walk across a narrow ledge without slipping. When a Check is described in the rules, it will often be followed by a shortened Ability name, like "... (*Agi.*)." This means that you add your *modifier* for that ability to the roll. You never add Ability Scores to Checks. A player cannot add modifiers to critical successes and failures.

Ability Score Maximums

Normally, ability scores are capped at 20 (providing a maximum roll modifier of +5). When making a new character, you may choose two abilities to uncap, meaning that you can continue to improve them past 20. A player does not need to choose which two

abilities they want to uncap right away, however, the decision to uncap an ability score becomes permanent once that ability score has been raised above 20.

Stats

Each character has three Stats, which are based on their Ability Scores.

Health

Add your *Endurance* score to your *Strength* or *Willpower* score, whichever is higher. This is your character's Health. Health is expended whenever your character gets hurt.

Stamina

Add your two highest scores from: *Strength*, *Agility*, *Endurance*. This is your character's Stamina, used to perform physical feats.

Magica

Add your *Willpower* score to your *Wisdom* or *Charisma* score, whichever is higher. This is your character's Magica. Magica is spent to cast and resist spells.

Traits

Traits flesh out a character's personality and capabilities. Positive traits, called Qualities, cost character points, while negative Traits, called Drawbacks, remit character points. Some ancestries have access to unique qualities that others don't. Starting ancestry qualities and birth signs cost no points.

Character Points

Character points are used to buy traits, as well as improve your character's attributes. Every level up grants a variable number of character points (depending on the significance of the advancement), which can be spent or stored for future use. At level 1, new characters begin with 3 character points.

Ancestry

Your character's *Ancestry* describes the *species* of person your character is. Aside from suggestions of personal appearance, your Ancestry provides the languages your character knows how to speak, and a unique starting *Trait*.

Birth Sign

The formations of the stars and other heavenly bodies play a major role in the *Monomyth's* default setting, *Hiraeth*. It is believed that the stars under which you are born can shape the course of your life. While optional, a player's choice of *Birth Sign* grants their character another starting trait.

- (**1**) **New Light** - You gain the **Oracle** quality. At the start of each in-game day, roll 1d20 and record the result. You may replace any single roll on the table with this result, be it your own roll, or the GM's roll.
- (**2**) **Last Frost** - You gain **The Chalice** quality. Every time you level up, you gain 1 extra point of health.
- (**3**) **Wind's Call** - You gain the **Zephyr** quality. In conflict, your movement is doubly swift. You can expend a stamina point to move two movement bands with one action.
- (**4**) **Flood's Wake** - You gain **The Lover** quality. As an action, you can pacify a hostile sentient creature for 1 minute. This quality may only be used once per day.
- (**5**) **First Bloom** - You gain the **Mind's Eye** quality. Once per day, you may place your hand against a wall, door, or container, and perceive whatever is on the other side or within.
- (**6**) **Mid Year** - You gain the **Wayfarer** quality. Whenever you would gain exhaustion, roll a d4. If the result is even, you instead do not gain exhaustion.
- (**7**) **Widow's Keen** - You gain the **Soldier** quality. Once per turn, you may use a reaction to increase a defense roll by 3. This may be used after you know the result of the roll.

- (**8**) **Summer's Hall** - You gain **The Trickster** quality. When your character is struck with a damaging spell. Roll a d20. If you roll a 18 or higher, this damage or effect (if appropriate) is reflected on the caster.
- (**9**) **Autumn Rest** - You gain the **Scribe** quality. Once per day you may accurately interpret any language you cannot read, but have heard spoken before.
- (**10**) **Harvest** - You gain the **Moon** quality. You can, at will, become aetherial for 1 minute. Once used, this ability recharged after 1d4 days.
- (**11**) **First Frost** - You gain **The Echo** quality. Once per day, you can apply the effect of a quality, spell, or attack to one additional creature you can see.
- (**12**) **Last Light** - You gain the **Sentinel** quality. You have advantage on initiative rolls and you cannot be surprised.
- (**13**) **Dead Lights** - You gain the **Dreamer** quality. You have the ability to summon a guardian spirit to aid you. Once used, this ability recharges after 1d4 days.

Conflict

Turn Order

When a conflict erupts, the GM should identify each side of the conflict. Often there will be two – the players and their opponents – but it is possible for there to be more.

All of the players make an ***Initiative Check*** (*Agi.*), while the GM does the same for the other sides of the conflict. The highest result from the players is compared to that of their foes. Whichever side is higher goes first, and then the sides alternate.

Taking a Turn

Each side of a conflict takes their turns simultaneously. If there are many players, the GM should consider breaking up their turns into two groups to keep the pace of the conflict up.

Every character gets ***3 Actions*** on their turn. Common actions include:

- ***Move*** one Distance Band relative to a point of interest.
- ***Attack*** an opponent or object.
- ***Use*** an object in your inventory or *Close* to you.
- ***Cast*** a spell (may demand more than one Action).
- ***Help*** someone else make an Ability Check, granting them advantage.
- ***Shove/Grapple*** an opponent to restrain them or knock them over.
- ***Climb/Jump*** over an obstacle with an Agility check.
- ***Drop Prone/Get Up.*** Dropping prone makes you harder to hit with ranged attacks (+5 defense), but makes you an easier target in melee (-5 defense).

This is not an exhaustive list of possible actions, but basically anything that requires you to make a Check, or causes someone else to make a Check, counts as one action. A player may only use the ***Help*** action once per turn.

Attacking

To attack an opponent within range of your weapon, make a Check corresponding to your weapon type. If a player takes a second or third *Attack Action*, it's made with *Disadvantage*.

- ***Melee*** attacks are made using *Str*.
- ***Ranged*** attacks are made using *Agi.*

Reactions

You may store one of your actions to use as a reaction outside of your turn. To store an action, you must specify beforehand a specific *Trigger* that would prompt your character to use their Reaction. Triggers include things like *seeing a foe walk through a doorway*, or *observing a signal from afar*.

Defending & Armor

When a foe attacks you, you must make a ***Defense Check*** to defend yourself.

- ***Melee*** attacks are defended against using *Str.* or *Agi*.
- ***Ranged*** attacks are defended against using *Agi*.

If you succeed in your Defense Check, you successfully avoid your foe's attack, and take no damage. If you fail, your opponent strikes you and you take damage, which you subtract from your health.

Armor

In the case that you fail your defense check and you are wearing armor, you can expend an ***Armor Point*** ***(AP)*** to instead take no damage. This represents your armor protecting you from harm, but breaking down in the process.

AP is represented by a d6. When you use AP to avoid damage, note it for later. During a rest, roll 1d6 for each expended AP.

- If the result is greater than your armor's base AP, then that AP is repaired and can be used again.
- If the result is equal to or less than your armor's base AP, then that AP is broken permanently until you get it fixed by a professional, and you may not roll for it again.

Note that AP does not stack. If your character were to wear padded cloth armor over their leather armor, their AP would be 2, not 2 + 1. The only way to improve your AP is by using a shield or wearing a helmet.

Taking Damage

When you are hurt, you subtract the damage from your ***Health Stat***.

Dying

When your Health reaches 0, your character falls unconscious and begins to die. At the start of each of your turns, before anyone else can act, you make a ***Death Check*** *(**End.**)* for your character.

If you roll higher than a 10, you succeed. Otherwise you fail. After 3 successes, your character regains consciousness with 1 Health. After 3 failures, your character dies. Critical successes and failures count double. Successes and failures need not be consecutive. If you take damage while unconscious, add one failure to your Death Check tally.

Injuries

Every time your character is reduced to 0 Health, they gain an Injury. These injuries vary based on the weapon or spell that knocked you down.

Injuries may be merely cosmetic, or they may have long-term consequences, such as a broken bone. Some Injuries will heal on their own, while others may require treatment. Some Injuries may never heal fully.

A character that has 3 untreated Injuries automatically and instantly dies when they reach 0 Health.

Death Knell

Instead of falling unconscious when you are reduced to 0 Health, you may instead choose to enter a ***Death Knell***.

During a Death Knell, you may only move and take one other action on your turn. In exchange, ***you automatically fail your Death Checks*** at the start of each turn.

If you take damage during a Death Knell, you add one failure to your Death Check tally as though you were unconscious.

Effects

Certain abilities, magic spells, and lingering injuries will impart effects on a character or monster. These effects may continue for a set period of time, or until remedied (usually through an Ability Check).

- ***Blinded*** creatures cannot see and automatically fail checks requiring sight. They attack and defend with disadvantage.
- ***Charmed*** creatures cannot harm the creature or object that charmed them. The charmer has advantage on social interactions with the charmed creature.
- ***Deafened*** creatures cannot hear and automatically fail checks requiring hearing.
- ***Frightened*** creatures spend their turns hiding or fleeing from the source of their fear.

- ***Invisible*** creatures cannot be seen and automatically succeed on checks to hide, unless moving, in which case they have advantage. They attack and defend with advantage.
- ***Restrained*** creatures may not move or take actions, and must succeed on a strength check to break from their restraints.
- ***Stuck*** creatures may take actions, but may not move. Like being *Restrained*, a stuck creature must succeed on a strength check to escape.
- ***Paralyzed*** creatures may not move or take actions, and automatically fail strength and agility checks. They have disadvantage to defend and all failed defense checks count as critical failures.

Ongoing Damage

Some effects inflict damage at the start of each turn, such as being on fire, being in acid, suffocating, or being poisoned.

Critical Hits

When you critically succeed on an attack or spell roll, the damage dealt is equal to the maximum dice damage, plus the damage roll. For example, a dagger dealing 1d4 damage will deal 4 + 1d4 on a critical hit.

When you critically fail a Defense Check against a foe's attack or spell, they deal critical damage to you in the same manner described above. If you expend AP, you instead take damage as though your Defence Check were a normal failure.

Character Advancement

Beats

It is important to remember that, despite all the dice rolling, fighting, and intrigue, this game is ultimately about collective storytelling. And any good story is about its characters.

When a player makes a character, they should have in mind the kind of development they want this character to undergo. Do they begin as a cynical loner who has to confront their own feelings of detachment to build real relationships with others? Consider what kinds of story beats, minor or major, a character like this might need to undergo to truly develop. Perhaps our cynical loner needs to go out of their way to help someone, or perform some act of self sacrifice for their friends that shows how they're changing during the adventure.

When a player does something like this, it should be acknowledged by the GM, and, if the GM deems the beat significant enough to the story, either narratively or symbolically, then they may allow the player to ***Lock In*** to their next level. All players must lock in before actually ascending to the next level, so players who have already locked in should act in ways that put other players in a position to do the same.

Milestones (Optional)

If beats don't really work for you or your group, then use ***Milestones*** instead. With milestones, all of the players level up together after accomplishing something significant together, like defending a town from invaders, defeating a particularly powerful monster, or completing a quest of narrative significance.

Leveling Up

When using the beats system, leveling up only occurs when all players have locked in their story beats, and the characters have some downtime to reflect on their beats together.

- Characters could talk about their pasts around a campfire, or while sharing a meal.
- The party could go carousing together (see: ***Carousing***).
- Characters could share their dreams and plans for the future.

These are merely suggestions. The actual matter of reflecting as a group is left up to the GM and the players. After reflecting (in whatever manner you choose), the party ***Levels Up***.

Leveling up grants players Character Points (typically 2-3), allowing them to increase their characters' Ability Scores (and consequently their Stats), and/or choose new traits. As a result, the party becomes stronger and more capable, ready to face bigger threats in the future.

Additional Rules

Limited Resources & Usage Dice

Some items, tools, and resources are described as ***Ud***, or having a ***Usage Die***. The size of the die is depicted as a number following *Ud*, such as *Ud6* representing a six-sided usage die.

When you use such an item, you roll the usage die afterwards. If the result is a 1 or 2, then your usage die shrinks, following this chain: ***Ud20*** > ***Ud12*** > ***Ud10*** > ***Ud8*** > ***Ud6*** > ***Ud4*** -> ***Depleted***.

When you roll a 1-2 on a Ud4, the item or resource is expended, and that character no longer has any more of the item. Consider a Ud4 potion; it's definitely good for one usage, but you only have a 50% chance of getting a second usage from it.

Ammunition

When tracking *Usage* for weapon ammunition, such as arrows, bolts, darts, bullets, and fuel, roll the usage die after conflict has been resolved, and only roll it once per conflict, not once per attack.

Armor Proficiency

A character who wears armor that they are not trained in wearing, they subtract the base AP value of the armor from all their Checks (*not* Death Checks).

Inventory

A character has a number of inventory slots equal to their ***Strength Score***. Most items occupy one inventory slot, but larger items, like suits of armor and heavy weapons, occupy two. Tiny objects, like notes, small pieces of jewelry (such as rings), can be piled together into one slot.

- ***Filling more slots than your Str. Score*** causes your character to become *Encumbered* and forces them to make all checks (*not* Death Checks) with *Disadvantage*.
- ***Filling more slots than double your Str. Score*** is not possible.

Items Breaking (Optional)

Sometimes, when characters are hurt, something in their possession may be destroyed. When a character takes falling damage, or suffers a similar malady, roll a d20. The item in the slot corresponding to the roll—if it is destructible—is destroyed.

Resting

When characters rest for at least an hour, they may roll any ***Broken Armor Points*** to see if they can repair it themselves. If they fail, the Armor Point remains broken until they see a professional tailor or blacksmith who can repair it.

For each hour that the characters rest, the players may do only one of the following:

- Roll 1d6 and recover that much Health.
- Roll 2d4 and recover that much Magica.
- Roll 2d6 and recover that much Stamina.

Additionally, players may choose to use a full 8 hours of sleep to remove one level of Exhaustion from their character. In doing so, however, they may not recover any stats during that time.

Healing

It is also possible for characters to recover Health, aside from resting. This usually takes the form of:

- Successful treatment with medical tools.
- Potions, Spells, and other magical means.
- Character Traits

It is not possible for a character to recover more than their maximum Health.

Temporary Health

Some magical effects and abilities grant Temporary Health. This is Health that is placed over your regular pool of Health, and gets expended first. Temporary Health cannot be healed.

Narrative Tokens

There are two kinds of narrative tokens in Monomyth; ***Resolve***, and ***Monologue*** tokens. In any campaign there should exist one of each token, which is passed between players and the GM to trigger events and shape the narrative of the unfolding fiction at the table.

- **Resolve** - The resolve token represents the will of the fiction. This token may only be passed between the party and the GM when it is spent. The campaign begins with the party being in possession of the resolve token. Imagine a scenario that has gotten out of hand for the party; they are traveling through a great underground city, pursued by hideous monsters until they arrive at a crumbling bridge. On the other side of the bridge, they can see light—a way out! Just then, disaster strikes! A monster smashes part of the bridge, separating the party: some of them can escape, but not all. Despite their greatest efforts, the gap between the stranded party members and their escaping allies only grows, and it seems all hope is lost. The party comes to a unanimous agreement: it is time to spend the resolve token. They hand the token to their GM and describe how a rock falls at just the right time, severing the bridge and sending the stranded party members flying to the far bank of the chasm it spanned. Against all odds, the party manages to escape. ***But now, the GM has the resolve token***, and they may choose to spend it when things are going all too well for the party. They've pulled off a complex and dangerous heist without a single slip up or hitch. It seems like the party is going to get away with it cleanly until the GM spends the resolve token, handing it back to the party. The GM describes how, in all the commotion

of their great escape, they lost track of their favorite NPC, who has fallen right into the hands of the evil mayor. The mayor taunts them from a balcony as the party makes their getaway, showing off his new prisoner. The party has gotten away with their heist, but they've attracted the attention of a new enemy—the evil mayor—an enemy who holds the life of their friend in his hands. The resolve token is a powerful narrative safety valve. The party uses it to diffuse tension when the situation becomes dire, and the GM uses it to ramp the stakes back up when things are too clean and easy.

- **Monologue** - The monologue token is passed between all players, including the GM. When a player is passed the monologue token, they are required to give a short, in-character monologue about their character's inner thoughts regarding their current situation. A player can pass this token to a GM to force them to play out the thoughts of an NPC, be they present or otherwise. The purpose of this token is to build dramatic irony by providing the players with information their characters might not know, because, while every player is a participant in the collaborative fiction being told at the table, they are also in some part the audience for each other's contributions. Monologues should be kept relatively brief and focused.

Scene Swap

The scene swap is a dynamic narrative mechanic where two dramatic scenes—occuring simultaneously in different parts of the world—are played out in parallel. The players see what is happening elsewhere while their characters are occupied, and as tensions rise, the players and the GM swap between scenes to exercise narrative control. While the players control one scene, the GM controls the other.

The GM initiates a scene swap by announcing it, pausing the current conflict to describe the alternate scene, and ceding control of the primary scene to the party. When this occurs, players enter a *loose* style of play, by which actions are not specifically tested by rolling dice, but rather by declaration of successes, failures, and the respective outcomes

of each. But players beware: a success for the party in one scene leads to a success for their foes in the alternate scene.

When things seem like they're getting out of hand the party can declare they are swapping scenes with the GM. For example, the party has tracked a group of bandits from their camp to a nearby forest where they are ambushed. A fiery melee erupts between the party and the bandits, but when it's clear the party is gaining the upper hand, the GM announces a scene swap: the bandits are a diversion! The party was deliberately led away from their camp while the main force of marauders has taken to ransacking the party's campsite. The party continues their fight, but every successful blow, every enemy dispatched brings the marauders back at camp one step closer to discovering the party's invaluable artifacts, or perhaps a character's cowering little brother, hiding under a yet unturned wagon. Rats! The GM describes how the bandits flip over the wagon to reveal the defenseless brother the party left behind at camp! The players announce they are switching scenes, and begin describing how the poor boy rolls out of the way of a dire blow, how the marauder gets his axe stuck in the mud just long enough for the boy to run away. But just as their successes affected the alternate scene, the party's advantages in the alternate scene translate to failures in the original scene. The GM describes how the bandits are managing to turn the tide of battle, how some of the characters are acquiring grievous wounds. The players decide they need to switch back. They describe how their characters notice smoke rising behind them—from the direction of their camp! They narrowly dispatch the last of the bandits, setting the rest of them to flight deeper into the woods, and double back to their campsite. They find it ransacked and ruined, but thankfully the little boy appears from a hidden spot along the treeline, trembling but untouched. Here, the scenes converge and the scene swap ends. Normal play resumes.

Party Stats

Wealth

The whole party shares a collective Wealth Score that combines currency and social credit. The party can spend Wealth to acquire new equipment, replenish their supplies, hire helpers and mercenaries, charter voyages, and much more.

The best way to get wealth is to plunder dungeons and sell treasure (gaining currency), or to help a community or faction (gaining social credit).

Reputation

The party may have a reputation that precedes them. News can travel quickly, and strong reputations can make impressions on various communities.

A positive reputation can result in greater recognition and trust by communities and factions, while a negative reputation can hinder the party in broader society. However, a negative reputation may gain them credibility with criminal elements, and even some high-class individuals who need things done "quietly and correctly."

Reputation additionally influences the relationships of retained NPCs with the party, extending or limiting the number of NPCs the party may travel with.

Supply

Supply is an abstraction of all the foodstuffs, fuel, equipment for camping, and other miscellaneous gear the party travels with.

For every day the party spends living in the wilderness, they expend one Supply. For each day that the party spends in the wilderness without Supply, they gain a level of *Exhaustion*.

Supply can be replenished in settlements. The amount of supply a party can travel with is equal to the number of characters, and can be increased by traveling in carts or with pack animals.

Shopping & Bartering

Buying

To buy items in a town, the party rolls a number of d6 equal to the settlement's ***Level*** (ranging from 1 to 5). Players are looking to create combinations with their dice to obtain the kinds of items they want. Getting multiples of the same number increases the quality of the items in a category. The items accessed by the roll may be bartered for without a significant cost to the party's Wealth.

- **1** - Adventuring & Survival Gear
- **2** - Alchemy, Medicine & Bio-craft
- **3** - Weapons & Wargear
- **4** - Magic, Tech & Arcana
- **5** - Armor, Constructs & Defensive Systems
- **6** - Culture, Luxury & Influence

The tiers of settlements follow:

- **1** - Villages and Hamlets
- **2** - Small towns
- **3** - Large Towns and Small Cities
- **4** - Mid-sized Cities
- **5** - Large Cities and Ports of Trade

There are two special rolls that are possible in Level 5 settlements:

- **Straights** - 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 or 2, 3, 4, 5, 6.
- **Full House** - Any pair and any trip.

These rolls can be played as though they are not a combination, but if the party desires, these two rolls correspond to special "deals" available in big cities. Straights represent rare artifacts, while Full Houses represent illicit goods and services.

In the case that players do not succeed in creating combinations for the items they are most interested in, they may expend 1 Wealth to purchase an item from another category at the same (or lesser) quality as the party's best combination. Items at higher qualities cost an additional 1 Wealth per quality above the party's best combination.

Alternatively, players may re-roll their dice a number of times equal to their reputation with the settlement. The party must re-roll *all of the dice*, unless one of its members has a trait that allows them to set some dice aside while bartering.

If a party has a negative reputation with a settlement, the number of dice they roll is reduced by their reputation. Players cannot barter in settlements if their negative reputation reduces their dice to 0.

Selling

When selling items to shops and vendors, players must list the items they are selling and sort them into the following categories:

- 1d4 - Treasure, artifacts, magic items.
- 1d8 - Art, gems, jewelry.
- 1d12 - Mercantile goods.
- 1d20 - Adventuring equipment.

After sorting, the party may roll a number of dice prescribed by the categories above (ex: selling 3 gems = 3d8). Note the number of rolls that are a 1, 2, or 3. These rolls count as 1 wealth. Players may re-roll a number of dice equal to their reputation with the settlement.

Resupplying

Wealth can be exchanged for Supply in settlements at a rate of 1 Wealth to 3 Supply. Players may improve the rate of exchange by the value of their reputation with the settlement. Hence, a settlement the party has 2 Reputation with will offer a deal of 1-to-5, while a settlement with which the party has -3 Reputation (or lower) will refuse to resupply the party.

Magic

Schools of Magic

Magical effects fall into five categories, each used for different purposes:

- ***Restoration*** magic heals wounds, wards against danger, and mends objects.
- ***Destruction*** magic inflicts violence upon the surrounding world.
- ***Illusion*** magic creates images and deceptions.
- ***Alteration*** magic changes the state of an object.
- ***Mysticism*** magic manipulates the laws of reality.

Certain character Archetypes may specialize in different schools of magic, gaining greater power and effects when casting those spells.

Spellcasting

Spellcasting is the spontaneous casting of a magic spell by a character using Magica.

Spell design is open-ended, provided the caster already knows the qualities of another, underlying spell. The caster and the GM create a spellbook together of signature spells, by which the caster proposes the effects of a spell, and the GM assigns a Magica cost for that spell.

Spells with new qualities can be learned from experience, teachers, and text.

Creating a Spell

Spells consist of a few basic things:

- ***Duration*** - How long does the spell last? Does it happen all at once, or is it an ongoing effect that the caster must maintain each turn. Spells that last longer cost more to cast.
- ***Distance*** - How does the spell travel? Choose one of; Touch, Target, Area. Touch spells require you to be able to physically touch your target, while Target spells

require that you see your target. Area spells cost the most, and can affect multiple targets at a distance.

- ***Magnitude*** - How potent is the effect of this spell? Each spell effect has a suggested basic magnitude, and increasing this will cost more Magica to cast.
- ***Effect*** - Finally, what is the effect this spell has on targets? Does it heal, or does it hurt? Pick from any effects your character knows already.

Spell Cost

Casting a spell requires the caster to expend an appropriate amount of Magica. Because spells in the Hiraeth system are customizable, the Magica cost of a given spell can vary depending on *how* it is cast. **Duration** indicates how many rounds a spell is active, usually just 1 (the round it is cast on). Additional rounds cost 1 magica to sustain the spell. This only applies to *Active* spells. **Distance** indicates how far away you can target your spell: *close/touch* (+0), *nearby* (+1), *far* (+2), *distant* (+3). **Targets** indicate how many targets you have chosen. Add 1 magica cost per target. Alternatively, you may choose to target an area, which costs 3 magica, but may be more cost effective in the long run. Finally, choose the **Magnitude** of the effect. A flame spell costs 1 magica per d8 of damage, so casting a 3d8 flame spell costs 3 points of magica due to magnitude.

- For instance, an exploding fireball spell costs the following: 1 magica for duration (1 round/instantaneous), 2 magica for distance (targeted distance of far), 3 magica for targets (area), and 3 magica for magnitude. This results in a fireball that hits all targets in an area up to a distance of far for 3d8 damage for a total magica cost of 9.

Rituals

Rituals are special spells that require time and materials to cast, but do not use Magica.

Because they do not require Magica, anyone with the proper preparation and knowledge can cast a ritual spell. Additionally, rituals are often much more powerful than spells

that are cast with Magica, but the possible consequences of messing up a ritual are much more dire.

Resisting Magic

While not everyone knows how to cast spells, everyone has the essence of Magica flowing within them. Characters can expend Magica to resist spells cast against them, provided they have the proper training and conditioning.

Alchemy

Anyone can create a potion provided they have the right tools, ingredients, and a fire to brew over. All potions have:

- ***Liquid Bases.*** This could be water, blood, chemicals, fermented liquids, etc.
- ***Dry Mix-Ins.*** This could include plants, spices, minerals, body parts, etc.

Characters make a *Wis.* Check. If they can cast a spell the effect they want to imbue in the potion, they make this Check with *Advantage*.

- ***Success!*** The potion is made (Ud4).
- ***Failure.*** The potion is made, but may not work as intended (Ud4).
- ***Critical Success!*** The potion is made (Ud8).
- ***Critical Failure.*** The ingredients are wasted.

Enchanting

Some magically talented characters can imbue mundane objects with magical essence. These usually come in the form of scrolls and wands that have limited uses before becoming mundane again. Those with extreme skill and power (and resources) can enchant an item that remains indefinitely magical. These are rare and expensive.

NPCs and Social Dynamics

Group Checks

Sometimes during an interaction, it may be necessary for multiple characters to make more than one proposal. Space out individual checks with roleplay to reflect the back and forth process of conversation and negotiation.

Outcomes

When the party makes a Proposal to an NPC, usually in the form of a social check, there is a spectrum of outcomes:

- ***Attack or Hinder.*** The NPC will not do what the party asks and will attempt to stop them from achieving their goal.
- ***Hinder, Little Risk.*** The NPC will seek to hinder the party, but only if they believe their interference will have little to no consequence for themselves.
- ***No Help.*** The NPC cannot, or will not fulfill the request, but won't stop the party from pursuing their goals.
- ***Help, Little Risk.*** The NPC will help the party, but only if it will not inconvenience them or put them in harm's way.
- ***Help, Minor Risk.*** The NPC will help the party, only going slightly out of their way to do so.
- ***Help, Major Risk.*** The NPC will help the party even if there is a significant risk or cost for themselves.

Retries

The party just failed a check but wants to continue negotiating, so what do we do?

- ***Let it Ride.*** Treat the result of the failed check as final. The players should finish roleplaying the scene with the failed check in mind.
- ***Transition to a Group Check.*** If the initial check was an individual failure, allow different characters to enter the conversation. Subsequent Checks are more difficult, but the NPC may reconsider their position.

- ***Alter the Deal.*** If the party succeeds, but the NPC determines the cost is too high to help, allow the party to change the deal slightly to rebalance the NPC's assessment.
- ***Limited Shift.*** If the party makes an NPC or group become *Hostile*, they may de-escalate the situation by making concessions, and repeating the check.
- ***Offer Alternative.*** The GM can *Alter the Deal* or provide a *Limited Shift*.
- ***Risk the Relationship.*** The party can push an NPC who is Friendly or Intimate to attempt a second roll. If they fail, the relationship is damaged until reconciliation occurs.

Negotiation

These rules are borrowed from Matthew Coville's *Draw Steel* system. Not every interaction evolves into a negotiation scenario, so these should only be reserved for significant conversations with NPCs where the party is seeking some sort of contentious resolution.

The negotiation begins with a certain amount of **Patience** (0-5) and **Interest** (0-5) on the part of the NPC. Based on the NPC's attitude, they may begin with different amounts of each:

- Hostile - 1 Patience, 1 Interest.
- Suspicious - 2 Patience, 1 Interest.
- Neutral - 3 Patience, 1 Interest.
- Open - 3 Patience, 2 Interest.
- Friendly - 3 Patience, 3 Interest.

Certain traits allow players to enter negotiations with a higher level of patience from the NPC.

The goal of a negotiation is to maximize an NPC's interest before spending all of their patience. Higher interest scores result in better deals and outcomes. Patience only goes down or stays the same.

Players present an idea or argument to the NPC of interest, and roll a charisma check. On a success, the NPC gains 1 interest and loses 1 patience. One a failure, the NPC loses 1 patience, but gains no interest. On a critical success (or a successful appeal to a *Motivation*), the NPC gains 1 interest and loses no patience. On a critical failure (or an appeal to a *Pitfall*), the NPC loses 1 interest and 1 patience. If the players are caught in a lie, the NPC loses 1 interest and 2 patience.

A negotiation ends when the NPC's patience reaches 0, and the NPC makes a final offer to the party. If the NPC's interest reaches 0 at any point, the negotiation ends with the NPC making no offer.

Motivations & Pitfalls

Typically an NPC should have at least 2 Motivations and at least 2 Pitfalls. Motivations are exactly as they sound, foundational ideals that the NPC aspires to. Motivations can be appealed to in an argument to improve the outcome and ease of the roll. A pitfall is an argument that sparks ire, discomfort, shame, fear, or a likewise negative reaction from an NPC. One NPC's motivations might be the pitfalls of another. Motivations can only be appealed to once in a negotiation.

Benevolence

- MOTIVATION: The NPC believes in sharing what they have with others.
- PITFALL: The NPC has a cynical view of the world, believing that no creature has a right to anything just by being alive.

Discovery

- MOTIVATION: The NPC wants to learn new lore, explore forgotten places, break ground with new experiments, or uncover artifacts lost to time.

- PITFALL: The NPC has no interest in finding new places, peoples, or ideas. It might be that the unknown scares them or makes them so uncomfortable that they'd rather remain ignorant.

Freedom

- MOTIVATION: The NPC wants no authority above them and desires no authority over others.
- PITFALL: The NPC believes that a world without authority is one in turmoil and chaos.

Greed

- MOTIVATION: The NPC desires wealth and resources above almost anything else.
- PITFALL: The NPC has no interest in accumulating wealth or other resources, and becomes offended if anyone tries to buy their participation.

Higher Authority

- MOTIVATION: The NPC remains staunchly loyal to a person or force they perceive as more important than themself.
- PITFALL: The NPC scoffs at the idea of serving another.

Justice

- MOTIVATION: The NPC wants to see the righteous rewarded and the wicked punished, however subjective their sense of who or what is good and evil.
- PITFALL: The NPC doesn't believe that the world is an inherently just place, and has no interest in making it one.

Legacy

- MOTIVATION: The NPC desires fame while alive and acclaim that lasts long after their death.
- PITFALL: The NPC cares nothing about leaving a personal mark on the world. To them, such vain thinking is nothing but a waste of time.

Peace

- MOTIVATION: The NPC wants calm in their life.

- PITFALL: The NPC hates being bored. They want excitement, drama, and danger in their life.

Power

- MOTIVATION: The NPC covets the authority of others.
- PITFALL: The NPC has no interest in authority for themself. They might respect the authority of others, but they hate the thought of ruling over other people.

Protection

- MOTIVATION: The NPC has land, people, information, items, or an organization they want protected above all else.
- PITFALL: The NPC is happy to leave others to fend for themselves. They don't believe that it's their responsibility to protect anyone other than themself.

Revelry

- MOTIVATION: The NPC just wants to have fun
- PITFALL: The NPC sees social encounters and hedonism as a waste of time.

Vengeance

- MOTIVATION: The NPC wants to harm another who has hurt them.
- PITFALL: The NPC believes that revenge solves nothing.

Ancestries

Humans

Bold, diverse, and adaptible, humans are known for learning quickly and using their wit and ambition to achieve mighty deeds.

- Human characters begin knowing how to speak two common languages.
- ***Ambitious*** - You begin with 2 extra level points.

Shei

Sometimes as friends, sometimes as rivals, the Shei are a magical people who have grown alongside humanity, exchanging human ambition for temperance and foresight.

- Shei characters begin knowing how to speak the Shei language and one other common language.
- ***Magical Bloodline*** - Choose two magical effects to become proficient with.

Volk

The wild-folk of the Redwood, the Volk possess the features of many wild animals – the horns and eyes of a goat, the tail of a monkey, and the temperament of a lion! Where they came from, nobody is quite sure.

- Volk characters can speak Redsong and one common language.
- ***Opposable Tail*** - You can manipulate objects with your tail using an Agility check (this means you do not need a free hand to do so). You have advantage against being knocked prone or being pushed against your will, and on Agility checks to keep your balance and to climb. You can climb as quickly as you can walk.

Alismana

Titan-moth tribals from the frozen northlands, Alismana are a fascinating and uncommon sight throughout the rest of the world, in which they often show little interest.

- Alismana characters can speak Ira and one common language.
- ***Moon Child*** - Under the light of the moon you deal an additional 1d6 Light damage whenever you deal damage. Your body can glow a pale green light at any time, illuminating a radius of 20 ft. This light can be called forth or extinguished as a free action.

Tuar

Bovine rulers of the highlands and remote places, the Tuar are a hearty folk fascinated by fighting and poetry.

- Tuar characters can speak one common language and can *read* one rare language.
- ***Indomitable*** - You cannot be frightened or intimidated, even by magical means. You have advantage on Strength checks to grapple other creatures and characters. When you are reduced to 0 Health, you automatically Death Knell.

Eld Machine

Forgotten pieces of a long-gone era, the Eld Machines are the workforce of an extinct civilization.

- Eld Machine characters may only *speak* one common language, but *understand* all common languages.
- ***Steel Body*** - You have resistance against all damage except lightning which you are vulnerable to. You are immune to poison, disease, and exhaustion (you may not expend stamina to perform actions), as well as being charmed, frightened, and petrified. You do not need food, water, or oxygen to survive. You cannot be healed by spells, potions, food, or rest. To recover Health, you must be *repaired* by an ally with tools or a trained technician.

Languages & Literacy

Languages

Many languages are spoken across the world of Hiraeth, some of them more common than others. There is no common tongue, so it is entirely possible that certain members of a very diverse party may not be able to speak directly to other members. Some languages will get your character more mileage with the average NPC than others.

Common Languages

- ***Morivian*** - The language of the Empire, Morivian is the closest thing to a lingua franca in Hiraeth. Still, its usage outside of the Empire drops off significantly.
- ***Askanian*** - A language spoken throughout the North, primarily by humans.
- ***Shei*** - The traditional language of the Shei, commonly used as the language of science and magic.
- ***Keshite*** - The language of the east. Commonly spoken among traders and merchants, Keshite is the language of money.
- ***Ogum*** - A shorthand language often used by the common folk, especially in rural regions.

Rare Languages

- ***Ash'rahn*** - The old clerical language of the Morivian Empire, many religious texts were originally written in Ash'rahn, though the language is less understood as time buries its extinct forebears.
- ***Redsong*** - A language of specific tones and uncommon sounds, Redsong is primarily spoken by the Volk living within the Redwood.
- ***Ira*** - The language used by the moth-folk of the North, the Alismana. It has its own, complex alphabet that is notoriously hard to read.
- ***Wrennish*** - An old, harsh language used by some scattered human tribes throughout highlands. More recently, it has been embraced by some of the Tuar tribes, as well.

- ***Aravan*** - A slow, thoughtful language used by nomads and frontiersmen in the western marches.
- ***Sirayem*** - A sing-song language of shifting meanings and compound words, used mostly by humans beyond the North who are themselves renowned poets.

Pseudo Languages

- ***Morse Code*** - A terse language consisting of long and short signals of light or sound. Commonly used when sending secret messages, silent messages, or transmissions along wires.
- ***Stitch-Code*** - A coding language used to communicate with machines and across the World Lines.

Literacy

Speaking is not always the same as being literate. Being able to read and write a language sometimes entails learning a whole new alphabet, and for characters who don't have traditional education, it is entirely plausible that they may not have had the opportunity to become literate in the languages they can speak.

This rule is entirely optional, but the following is a list of alphabet systems to gauge the difficulty of learning different languages based on which languages a character already knows.

- ***Auroran*** - This ancient lettering system is the most commonly used in Hiraeth. It uses linear sets of symbols to represent sounds, written in vertical stacks. It is used by the *Morivian, Keshite, Ash'rahn, Redsong,* and *Wrennish* languages. It is written and read horizontally—left to right—when interacting with machines.
- ***Florit*** - This alphabet has been used by the Shei for ages. Words are represented as circles with loops and hooks compiled as symbols stemming from the center. It is read clockwise, starting from the bottom of each word-circle. It is an abjad-style alphabet, meaning it contains no vowels. It is used by the *Shei, Askanian* and *Sirayem* languages.

- ***Arisect*** - The written language of *Aravan* speakers, Arisect, is a syllabary language, meaning it uses over 80 different symbols to represent all of the possible syllables of the *Aravan* language. Some of the symbols look similar to those used by the Auroran alphabet, but they do not often correspond to similar sounds.
- ***Lepita*** - The written language of *Ira*, used primarily by the Alismana moth-folk. It is a phonetic alphabet in which two kinds of symbols are paired together to create variations on the base sounds used in *Ira*.
- ***Ogum*** - Ogum is written as a series of scratches and hashes, generally imprinted on the sides of trees and stones, read vertically top-to-bottom.

Injuries, Exhaustion, Stress

Your characters are capable of achieving great things, but they are still just people, and there is only so much a person can take before they start to break down. In Monomyth, this is tracked in 3 ways, corresponding to the 3 stats, Health (Injuries), Stamina (Exhaustion), and Magica (Stress).

Injuries

Whenever your character is knocked unconscious by falling to 0 Health, they receive an Injury corresponding to the type of damage that knocked them unconscious. For example, being struck with a fireball may leave you with severe burns, while being impaled with a spear will net you a gaping laceration.

When injuries are serious like this, they affect your character in negative ways, and take time to heal. In some cases, they may never fully heal, and represent ongoing challenges that your character must work around.

A character cannot have more than 3 active injuries. When a character acquires their 4th injury, they die.

Exhaustion

The daily work of an adventurer is taxing, and not always sustainable. Strenuous activities cost Stamina, and sometimes, more is demanded of your character even when they have no gas left in the tank. In the case that you need to perform a tiring task while having no Stamina in reserve, you gain a level of Exhaustion.

Exhaustion starts small, but stacks, causing worsening effects. A typical character can sustain 3 levels of exhaustion. At their 4th, they push themselves too hard and sustain an injury in line with the activity that pushed them over the edge. Exhaustion can be lost by resting.

Stress

Traveling the world and facing down challenges every day is sure to cause a lot of stress. The average person might not always think much about the stress they're under, but magicians, witches, and other magically talented folk need to make sure to manage their stress carefully. A common way for them to gain stress is by casting spells they don't have the Magica to compensate for.

For non magic users, stress can be gained by encountering particularly horrifying creatures, experiencing relationship strain, or through the exploitation of a flaw by other characters.

Stress should not be taken lightly, because it will compound and pile up, just like anything else. A typical character can sustain 3 levels of stress. At their 4th, they suffer a mental break and gain negative traits that impact their relationships and how they receive information from the GM. Alternatively, they may gain a level of Exhaustion.

Stress can be relieved by participating in fulfilling downtime activities, like reading, exercising, bathing, indulging a vice, etc.